
AI Foundations

The basics before we open Render • AVC 248 • Week 1

“Just enough to use it well.”

This is not an AI class. We will cover only what you need to use AI thoughtfully.

START HERE

What is an LLM?

A large language model is trained on huge amounts of text to predict the next words. So at heart it is a very strong pattern and prediction engine.

It often sounds confident, even when it is wrong.



Not a person



Not a search engine



Not always right



A prediction engine, not a mind.

Powerful, but it does not know things the way you do.

Great at / Not reliable for



GREAT AT

- Drafting
- Summarizing
- Brainstorming
- Reorganizing
- Explaining
- Tailoring your own material



NOT RELIABLE FOR

- Facts and citations without checking
- Current events
- Some math
- Anything needing your personal data
- Anything needing your judgment

THE BIG CAUTION

It can make things up



Models can hallucinate.

They can state wrong things confidently, made-up facts, fake names, invented numbers, all in a convincing tone.

You are the editor.



Always verify facts, names, and numbers.



Never trust blindly.



Always check before you use it.

THE RECIPE

How to write a good prompt

1

Give it a role and context



2

Be specific about the task



3

Give it examples or your real material



4

Say the format you want



5

Iterate and refine



SEE THE DIFFERENCE

Weak vs strong prompt

WEAK

“Write my resume.”

No role, no context, no material, no format.
You get something generic that is not really yours.

STRONG

“You are a hiring manager for junior motion designers. Here is my current resume [paste] and this job posting [paste]. Suggest edits to my bullet points so they match the posting’s language, keep it truthful to my real experience, and return a bulleted list of suggested changes.”

The strong prompt gives role, context, your material, and a format. **And you still edit the result.**

GROUND RULES

Use it ethically and responsibly



A partner, not a ghostwriter.



Do your own thinking.



Never input personal, sensitive, or other people's private data.



Check for bias and errors.



Disclose or credit per the assignment.



Use it intentionally, given the environmental cost.



**Now you are
ready for Render.**

“Your career launchpad is next.”